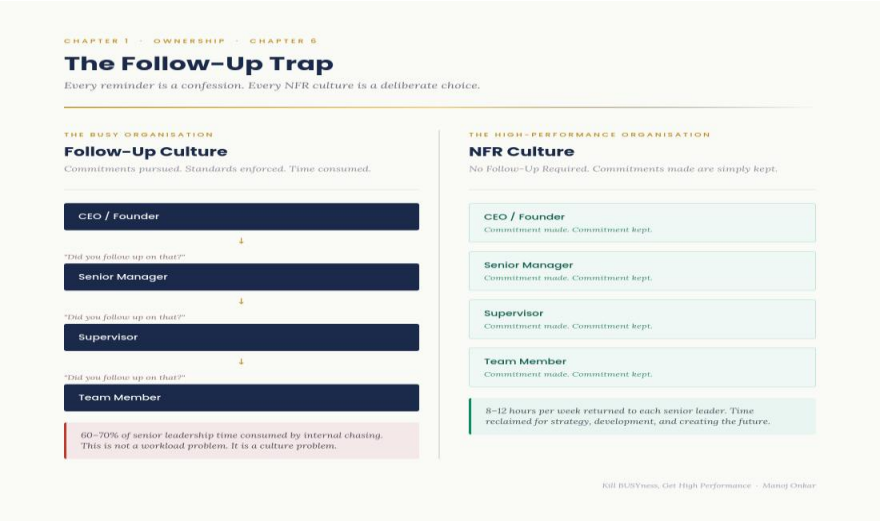

CHAPTER 6

Ownership

> *"Culture is not what is written on the wall. It is what happens when nobody is watching."*

The Two Cultures: BUSY vs. High Performance

You do not need a culture survey.

Here is the most direct route to understanding what culture your organisation is actually living in right now. One question. Simple. Blunt. Necessary.

If follow-up messages are a normal part of your week — if status chases are expected, if reminders are built into the workflow, if the

question "did you follow-up on that?" is a standard part of how things move forward — then you are living in a BUSY culture.

That is not a criticism. It is a diagnosis. The first step toward changing something is to see it clearly.

Follow-up is not a management tool. Follow-up is a confession that commitments are not honoured without reminders, that accountability is enforced rather than owned, that the organisation runs on surveillance rather than trust.

Senior leaders lose eight to twelve hours every week — sometimes more — chasing updates, clarifying missed commitments, and extracting basic status. That is not a productivity problem. That is a cultural problem. And it can only be solved at the cultural level.

How Follow-Up Cultures Accumulate

Nobody designed a follow-up culture deliberately. It accumulated. One unfollowed commitment normalised at a time. One missed deadline absorbed without consequence at a time. Until chasing became the rhythm of the organisation — so embedded, so expected, that nobody questions it any more.

The manager who sends the reminder is doing what the culture taught them to do. The team member who waits for the reminder is doing the same. Neither is failing individually. Both are participating in a culture that has, incrementally, replaced ownership with enforcement.

And because it accumulated so gradually, most organisations do not see it as a culture problem. They see it as a workload problem, or a systems problem, or a people problem. They add more tracking tools, more project management software, more dashboards — which adds more things to follow up on, which creates more BUSYness.

Google's Project Aristotle — a two-year study of 180 teams — found a precise connection between culture and follow-up behaviour. In teams where psychological safety was high and accountability was genuinely owned, commitments were honoured at a far higher rate. The follow-up message was rarely needed because the norm of honouring commitments was real rather than symbolic. In teams where psychological safety was low, the pattern reversed: more follow-up, more check-ins, more status meetings. Not because people were less capable — but because the culture had not established that commitments were real. The infrastructure of chasing had replaced the culture of ownership.

The antidote is not more infrastructure. It is ownership. And ownership begins with the leader.

The Two Cultures, Side by Side

Meetings. In a BUSY culture, meetings are an ego trip. Some people love to talk. Some hide — present enough to be counted, absent enough to avoid accountability. Follow-up items from the last meeting are reviewed at the start of the next, because most were not completed. In a High-Performance culture, every meeting has a precise purpose, a decision to be made, a problem to be solved.

Outcomes are clear, owned, and not followed up on — because they do not need to be.

Customers. In a BUSY culture, customers are a transaction — revenue, pipeline, renewal dates. Nobody has asked how the customer talks about the organisation in the rooms it is not in. In a High-Performance culture, the customer's long-term objectives are understood, not just stated. Their challenges are anticipated before they are voiced. The question is not "How do we renew?" but "How do we become structurally essential to their future?"

Accountability. In a BUSY culture, accountability is enforced. Work advances only after checking. In a High-Performance culture, accountability is owned. Commitments are explicit. When a risk emerges, people communicate proactively — before being asked, while options still exist. They do not wait to be followed up on. No Follow-Up Required.

Standards. In a BUSY culture, standards are negotiable — they bend under pressure, once bent, never quite restored. Mediocrity becomes the expectation. In a High-Performance culture, standards are non-negotiable. Lower the standard, and you lower the belief. The lower the belief, the lower the performance.

The Future. In a BUSY culture, the future arrives as disruption, and the organisation scrambles to respond. In a High-Performance culture, the organisation senses the direction of change before it becomes undeniable — making strategic choices today for the world that is arriving, not the world that has already passed.

Why People Show Up. In a BUSY culture, people are doing a job. Professionally competent. Delivering slightly below capability — because that is the level the culture has calibrated to. They will leave when a better offer arrives. In a High-Performance culture, people are part of something. They stay because the purpose is real, the standards genuine, the leadership worthy of full commitment.

The numbers behind this gap are familiar by now — Gallup has measured them consistently across years and geographies. In organisations where managers are truly engaged and develop their people, 70% of teams follow. In organisations where they do not, the number drops to 21%. The gap between 70% and 21% is not a strategy gap or a talent gap. It is a culture gap.

HCL Technologies offered one of the most deliberately documented examples of this shift in Indian corporate history. Under Vineet Nayar, the organisation inverted its stated hierarchy: Employees First, Customers Second. The argument was precise — if the people closest to the customer own their work genuinely, customer outcomes will follow as a consequence. They will not need to be enforced. Employee satisfaction scores rose 55% in three years. Revenue grew fourfold in the same period.

NFR: No Follow-Up Required

The operating standard that separates these two cultures can be stated in four words:

No Follow-Up Required.

In our organisation, a commitment made is a commitment honoured. Leaders and teams operate with such clarity, ownership, and integrity that no follow-ups are required.

Toyota's Production System is the most complete operational expression of this standard that exists anywhere in the world. Under the TPS, any worker on any production line has the authority — and the responsibility — to stop the entire line the moment they spot a defect. Not escalate. Not report. Stop. Ownership is not just permitted at every level. It is structurally required.

And here is what makes the Toyota example so striking:, managers become *concerned* when workers are not periodically stopping the line. The absence of ownership being exercised is itself a signal that something is wrong. In a BUSY culture, the follow-up message arrives when a commitment is not honoured. At Toyota, the alarm is triggered when ownership is not being demonstrated.

That inversion — concern in the absence of independent action rather than in its presence — is what a fully institutionalised NFR culture looks like. Not as aspiration. As operational design.

Five of our client organisations have begun building an NFR culture and are at different stages of implementation. None would claim to have arrived. But all have shifted. Follow-up meetings are shorter. Status-chasing conversations are less frequent. Leaders are beginning to reclaim hours per week that were previously consumed by the infrastructure of chasing. The journey from a follow-up culture to an NFR culture is not short. But the evidence from these organisations confirms what the theory predicts: once

the leader personally models the standard — once the CEO honours their own commitments without being followed up on — something in the organisation's nervous system begins to change.

Senior leaders who stop chasing and start holding the NFR standard free up eight to twelve hours per week. That is a full working day returned to strategic work, relationship building, deep thinking — the very things that a BUSY organisation can never find time for.

Key Finding	Source
Any Toyota worker can stop the production line; managers concerned when workers DON'T stop it	*Toyota Production System; Jeffrey Liker, "The Toyota Way" 2004*
High-accountability teams honour commitments at higher rates; low-safety teams compensate with more follow-up	*Google Project Aristotle 2014; Amy Edmondson*
Engaged-manager organisations: 70% team engagement vs 21% global average	*Gallup, State of the Global Workplace 2025*
HCL "Employee First, Customer Second": 55% employee satisfaction increase; 4x revenue in 3 years	*Vineet Nayar, "Employees First, Customers Second" (2010)*

This Culture Can Change

Japan, in the aftermath of the Second World War, was producing goods that were a global synonym for cheap and low quality. By 1945, Japan's industrial output had fallen to less than 10% of pre-

war levels. Within fifteen years, guided by W. Edwards Deming's philosophy of total quality, industrial production had not merely recovered — it had reached 350% of pre-war levels. Japan had redefined what quality meant for the entire world. Not through resources. Through will and persistence.

Satya Nadella inherited a Microsoft defined by what he called a "know-it-all" culture — siloed, politically exhausting, falling behind on every major platform shift. His first declaration as CEO was not about the product roadmap. It was about culture: "Our culture change will be the leading indicator of our future success." Changed through persistent, personally modelled leadership — one belief, one behaviour, one standard at a time. Microsoft's market capitalisation grew from $300 billion to $2.5 trillion. Revenue grew 2.5x. The stock price rose twelvefold. The cultural shift from "know-it-all" to "learn-it-all" preceded the commercial success.

Almost all organisations we work with have demonstrated significant culture changes — shifting from ego-centric to eco-centric cultures; from instruction and task-master leadership to collective leadership that co-creates new futures; from transactional client relationships to collaborative partnerships; from random sales processes to disciplined consultative selling; from blaming each other and being a department leader to being a company leader with ownership of the whole.

Everything in the BUSY column can change. Excellence is possible for every organisation, even those that have drifted furthest from it.

Exercises — Chapter 6: Ownership

Follow-up culture is not a small irritation. It is a visible confession of what the culture really is. Use these exercises to diagnose it without excuse — and reset the standard that should have been normal all along.

Exercise 1: The Follow-Up Log

For seven days, record every reminder, chase, escalation, and status extraction that was required from you or your senior leaders. Count them. Write the number.

— At the end of the week, which functions, people, or meetings generated the most follow-up?

— What does that pattern reveal about the real culture?

— How many hours did follow-up consume from your week? Multiply by 52. That is the annual cost of the culture you have normalised.

Exercise 2: What Does Chasing Mean

Not all follow-up comes from the same source. Diagnose yours:

— Where is follow-up caused by unclear commitments — people did not actually understand what they agreed to?

— Where is it caused by weak capability — people cannot deliver at the level required?

— Where is it caused by tolerated non-ownership — people have learned that reminders will come, so they do not have to act until they do?

Each of these has a different solution. Clarity fixes the first. Development fixes the second. Culture, held firmly by the leader, fixes the third.

Exercise 3: The NFR Reset

Begin building the No Follow-Up Required standard:

— Write the exact standard: What must happen before a commitment is made? What must happen while it is being executed? What is the expected behaviour the moment risk appears?

— Which leader will you coach first — because their team has the most normalised reminders?

— What one meeting rhythm, reporting habit, or tolerance will you stop this month to begin building an NFR culture?

The Mirror Questions

— If you had to honestly place your organisation on a scale from 1 (pure BUSY) to 10 (High Performance), what number would you choose? What would it take to move one point higher?

— What cultural behaviour do you personally model that, if your entire organisation modelled the same way, would move the culture in the wrong direction?

— What is the one cultural norm you know needs to change — and that you have been tolerating because the cost of changing it feels too high?

The Commitment

I will uphold one cultural standard this week that I have been allowing to slide, and I will do it clearly, so the organisation sees what I am modelling:

The opposite of a reminder culture is not pressure. It is ownership.

You have now reflected. You have owned. You have seen the two cultures clearly — including which one you are living in right now. Now it is time to assert.

Chapter 7 makes the distinction that separates every great leader from every merely competent one. Not intelligence. Not experience. Not even strategy. The choice between managing what already exists — and creating what has not yet been built. That choice is made daily. In hundreds of small moments. This chapter names it.

A | *Assert*

Set non-negotiable standards — in yourself first, then in every person.